The Scenic Route

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40972620.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Heavy Angst, Compulsory Heterosexuality, Pining, Mutual Pining, Angst with a Happy Ending, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Coming Out

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by ResFlower

Summary

Catra likes her.

The thought is like a punch to her gut it leaves her winded. It scrambles her thoughts and leaves her palms sweating. It must be because Catra is her best friend, the person in the world who most understands her. Because she's not you know—

"I'm not gay ."She blurts out. Catra shrinks further pulling her hand away and averting her eyes. Adora reaches out and puts a tentative hand on her shoulder. "Catra."She fumbles. "You're the most important person in the world to me."She pleads, hoping that it's enough.
...
"We'll always be friends or ."She whispers furiously . Catra dries her eyes and sends her a lukewarm smile. "It's just a crush, I'll get over it."

There's a growing pit in Adora's stomach at the thought. She doesn't know why, she should want Catra to get over her, but it feels like she's losing her right now. She ignores it.

"Yeah, you'll get over it. And well be friends like we always have been."Somehow it doesn't ring true for Adora, but she wishes it so. Itll be enough. It has to be.

OR

Five times Adora and Catra almost find each other and the one time they do.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

One

They are studying biology when it happens. Catra and Adora are both sitting on her bed, papers and notebooks strewn about as they try to make heads or tails of what a cytolysis is and why they should give a damn.

Catra's laughing at some lame joke she says when her face suddenly turns soft. "Adora, I like you." She whispers, her big eyes are hard to look away from.

The sentence does something funny to her heart, but she ignores it. Adora can't help but pull a face and grin broadly at Catra. "Aw Cat, I love you too!"

She's about to turn back to her notebook when her best friend puts her hand in hers. "No Adora, I mean...I don't mean it like that."

Catra studies her face willing her to understand whatever she's trying to say. Adora stops for a moment turning to really look at her friend.

She's clearly nervous, her hand smoothing over the sheet between them before she pulls it back into her lap. She almost trembles and Adora tightens her hold on the one hand in hers to try and stop it.

She gives Adora a pleading look and then she gets it.

Oh.

Oh.

Catra *likes* her.

The thought is like a punch to her gut, it leaves her winded. It scrambles her thoughts and leaves her palms sweating. It must be because Catra is her best friend, the person in the world who most understands her. Because she's not, you know—

"I'm not gay ."She blurts out. Catra shrinks further pulling her hand away and averting her eyes. Adora reaches out and puts a tentative hand on her shoulder. "Catra."She fumbles. "You're the most important person in the world to me."She pleads, hoping that it's enough.

Catra refuses to look up, but Adora can tell her eyes are shining with tears. She wants to comfort her friend but feels it might do more hurt than good when she's the one that's causing the hurt.

"I should've known I guess. But, I had to say something."She mumbles looking down as she sniffs.

Adora can't resist anymore, pulling Catra into her arms.

"I'm so sorry ."She whispers as her own tears stain her face. The two girls sit there crying together for a long moment. "I don't want us to stop being friends. You're my best friend, Catra."

Catra crushes her back, as if thatll make it so that things stay the same between them. "We'll always be friends for ."She whispers furiously. Catra dries her eyes and sends her a lukewarm smile. "It's just a crush, I'll get over it."

There's a growing pit in Adora's stomach at the thought. She doesn't know why, she should want Catra to get over her, but it feels like she's losing her right now. She ignores it.

"Yeah, you'll get over it. And well be friends like we always have been."Somehow it doesn't ring true for Adora, but she wishes it so. Itll be enough. It has to be.

Two

It's a fun game, Adora thinks, because it benefits the more inexperienced in the group for once. She's not one for a lot of the

other college activities but these big dorm hangouts were always a blast.

"Never have I ever kissed a girl," Adora pronounces triumphantly . The group groans loudly almost all of them dropping a finger.

Bow looks like he's thinking about what to say for his turn when someone else speaks up.

"Wait, wait, I don't believe this." Mermista protests loudly pointing an accusatory finger at Adora.

She furrows her brow. "What do you mean?" She tucks her knees up to her chest as if that'll hide how nervous she feels under the other girl's stare.

"C'mon *you*? Never kissed a girl?" She rolls her eyes. "I mean, we all see the way you look at Catra."

Everyone in the dorm room freezes and Adora tries not to crumble under the cautious glances.

"Drop it, Mermista." Glimmer hisses under her breath, nudging the newcomer with her elbow.

Mermista sloshes her drink a little as she stands up. "Why? I mean clearly—"

"That's enough." Catra cuts in. "I've never kissed Adora." She confirms. For a moment, the silence stays tense as Mermista and Catra stare each other down. Then, Catra grins provocatively. "But I have kissed *you*, so put a finger down, Mermy."

The group laughs as Mermista grumbles, a blush forming on her cheeks as she stares at Catra. It makes Adora want to deck her.

Later that night, she bunks up with Catra. It's a bad combination of too many drinks and too few beds.

"Thanks. For earlier ."She doesn't have to be specific. Cara nods.

Catra, charismatic as always, managed to distract the whole group from what would surely be a painful explanation of how Adora and Catra are only friends. Could only ever be friends. She's relieved that she didnt have to deal with that tonight

"Have you ever thought about it?"Catra whispers, her face so close Adora could make out the light freckle right on the bridge of her nose. It's Adora's favorite.

"What?"She asks, distracted by Catra' s face. She tucks her hand behind her head as she turns to face Catra more fully.

"Kissing girls?"Catra clarifies. Adora hears *kissing me*. Of course she's thought about kissing Catra. All the time. She and Catra are pined at the hip it, would be weird if she hadnt thought about it. Catra's just so meaningful to her and objectively pretty . She's sure lots of people think about kissing her.

"I mean, I think everyone has at some point."She answers diplomatically, not wanting to get into the specifics.

Catra gives her a strange look. "Um, I'm pretty sure that isn't an everyone thing, Adora."

Adora feels a bit queasy at the comment combined with the furrow on Catra's brow.

"I'm tired. Im going to sleep."She blurts out. Catra nods her head slowly pressing her lips together.

Adora turns to face the wall, making sure she isnt touching Catra anymore. She feels cold. She doesnt sleep all that much that night.

Three

She can't breathe when Catra looks at her like that, so soft it feels like she's touching her from a distance. Catra's dressed to the nines in the suit that they'd picked out for the occasion.

"You look beautiful, Adora." She steps closer, turning Adora to face the mirror. "Radiant."

She smiles at Catra through the mirror, taking in the white dress and understated veil.

"Thanks, Cat." She smiles at her feeling warmth past the nerves for the first time in days.

Catra's smile dims in response. "He's going to pass out when he sees you walking towards him." She pauses for a moment biting her lip. "I know I would."

"Cat..." She turns around, giving her a look.

Catra's eyes plead with her as she takes her hand. "You don't have to marry him."

"I know that. I want to." She can't make herself look Catra in the eyes as she says it, choosing to focus on a canvas on the far wall of the room.

Catra eyes her for a moment, far from impressed. "Well, you sure *sound* enthused."

"It's just the nerves." She convinces herself. "He's a good man."

"He is." She agrees readily. "But does he make you happy?" She asks the question like it's the only thing that matters to her.

Adora swallows the knot growing in her throat. He's good to her, a warm caring person, but he isn't where she gets her joy from. That lays with Catra.

But she's never gotten that fulfillment from *any* of her romantic relationships. She's quietly pondered if maybe there was something wrong with her; that she just doesn't connect to people the way that others seemed to. And with him, well, he's patient and lovely and it's been *three years*.

What else was she supposed to do when he asked? Say no and burn everything they *did* have together? Their relationship has a quiet understanding and friendship she values. Adora doesn't want to toss it all away just because the passion might not be all there.

So instead of thinking about it too hard, she lies.

"He does make me happy." She nods. "I care about him, and I want to spend my life with him." It will have to be enough.

Catra gives a small sigh that ends with a whimper and then a closed-lip smile. "Alright, then. Ready to go down the aisle?" She offers her hand out and Adora's heart flip flops in her chest. She ignores it and takes her hand.

"Yeah. Born ready."

When her hand leaves Catra's and meets his at the altar, she feels a voice inside of her screaming that she's made a mistake. She muffles it and leaves it to die.

Four

It feels like Adora's world is falling apart.

"What do you mean you're moving to Bright Moon?" She asks, aghast.

Catra takes a small sip from their coffee cup as if she didn't take their weekly coffee meeting and just drop a bomb on her. She

continues to walk down the path they always do, minding the other pedestrians as she keeps pace with Adora.

"There's nothing left for me here, Adora. I want to see new things. This job offer is a good opportunity for me." She explains stoically, looking forward and moving one foot in front of the other. It feels like Catra's already gone.

Adora grabs her arm and pulls her off the path under a big oak tree. "Bright Moon is across the country, Catra." She points out the obvious. "You're going to miss so much! Finn just started walking and Scorpia and Perfuma are getting married next year"...

She loses steam as she catches the almost angry look on Catra's face. They stand in silence for a moment, a soft breeze ruffling Catra's gorgeous hair. Adora can't help but look at her.

Her expression softens for a moment as she squeezes Adora's hand. "We'll see each other and there's video call and text. You're busy with Finn and I'm busy with work, we usually don't see each other all the time anyways."

Adora lets that lie slide. Catra's over with Finn so much she's starting to think Finn might say Catra before Adora.

"It's not the same, Cat. I want you here." She can hear how childish she sounds but she doesn't care, the desperation of not being close to Catra clawing at her.

Irritation flickers across her face as she stares Adora down. "You want me to stay?" She challenges.

She nods, the answer is obvious. "Of course."

Catra steps closer, her face just a hair's breadth away from Adora's. "Then give me a reason to." She says flatly like she's expecting Adora to fail.

Everything in Adora begs her to press forward. "But Finn."She whimpers, not even thinking to say that it’s not what she wants. Things in her marriage aren't good but Finn is the best thing she has. She doesn't want to hurt them, break their family apart.

Catra shakes her head in disbelief, taking a step back. "There's always something."She presses her lips together . "Look Adora, I can't keep my life on hold for you indefinitely. You have bigger priorities than me ~~her~~ her eyes flicker to the ring on her finger then back to her face~~an~~ and I need to put myself first."

Adora stares at her, not believing what she’s hearing. "I'm ~~I've~~ never asked you to do that."Catra’ s free to live her life just like Adora is.

Catra laughs, a hard noise that seeps out from her gut. "Y ou never had to, Adora."She gives Adora a tired, sad look. "That's what love is."She looks away wiping her face. "But I need to love myself too, and this?This is killing me."

"I'm being a terrible friend to you, arent I?"The realization leaves her cold. In her frantic need to keep Catra close, she failed to consider her feelings at all.

Catra doesnt confirm the sentiment, maybe because it’ s so obvious. "If you don't want me, you need to let me go."She whispers finally looking up at Adora. Her eyes are filled with tears and she looks like she hasnt slept in a week.

Adora knows now that wanting has never been the issue. She'd finally confessed, at least to herself, that she's only really attracted to women. Her husband is her friend and she’s mostly okay with that.

Catra deserves to be with someone who will love her fiercely. Unapologetically. Publicly. And that simply isnt in the cards for Adora.

She pulls Catra into a hug, trying to maybe leave a piece of her soul with her. "Let me know when you're packing. I'll come help."She mumbles into her shoulder.

Catra holds her back, one hand wrapped around her waist, the other running through her hair. "I'll still be here for you. Always."She says softly.

"I know , Cat. I'm here for you too."

Five

"Auntie Catra!"They yell running out to meet Catra as she hops out of the ride share, luggage in tow. It’s been two months since her last visit and Finn had been counting the days.

Finn jumps up and Catra is agile enough to catch them, a grin of pure joy on her face as she presses a kiss to their cheek. They're still small enough that they rest easily on her hip when she scoops them up and tickles them for good measure.

Adora watches from the porch, a smile on her face. True to her word, Catra visits as often as she can. It's still way fewer visits than Adora is happy with, but Catra was right. It was a good job opportunity and Adora couldn't stand in the way of what made Catra happy .

"Hey Adora."She offers her an apologetic grin as she gestures to the kid on her hip and her luggage for why she doesn't offer a warmer greeting. Adora takes the luggage from her hand, but not before squeezing it.

"How was your flight? Are you tired? Do you need anything?"She wants Catra to feel at home here.

Catra laughs rolling her eyes. "Geez. You're such a mom."Finn laughs along even though she’s sure they don't get the joke. "I'm

fine, I have everything I need.”She looks down and smiles at Finn then up at Adora.

Like it always does when Catra looks at her that way, her heart tries to beat its way out of her chest.

“Legos,”Finn says slowly with a commanding tone.

She looks back down at the child on her lap with a thoughtful expression. “Legos?Why didn't you say something earlier?”She glances up at Adora. “I see you gave them your nerd gene.”

Adora sputters as Catra turns on her heel and heads to Finn’s room promising to play with anything they want. She stares after that woman, not sure she knows anything anymore.

It’s another few hours before Finn is tucked into bed, sound asleep after all the excitement of the day and their guest’s arrival. Catra and Adora finally have some time to themselves, sitting in the living room, each with a glass of wine in hand.

"How are you doing?"Catra asks imploringly . "Y ou know with… everything.”

Adora shrugs. "I mean I'm fine. It’ s been a long time coming. You know we get on well."Her divorce is recent but amicable enough. "I'm not broken hearted if that's what you're asking."

She'd been absolutely devastated when Catra moved away. It put some things in perspective for her. She's been on a few dates since the divorce and she's confident she's a lesbian. She's been meaning to tell Catra that but every time she thinks about it she chickens out. It feels like one wrong move will break everything between them now.

"W ell, I'm glad that you're doing well with it."She still eyes Adora with concern.

"I've been dating again." She blurts out. Catra's eyebrows raise to her hairline, but she nods. "I've been seeing women, I mean." Adora finally gets it out.

The air around them gets thicker as Catra stares at her, setting down her wine glass. The room feels hotter as her best friend drags her eyes over her.

"Women?" She echoes softly almost to herself.

"Yeah. I'm a lesbian." She bites her lip as she waited for a reaction.

Catra blinks up. "Okay. Anything else you want to tell me?" The words sound like she's trying to lead a horse to water.

Adora feels at a loss. "Um, no?"

Catra stares off into space. "Could I have done anything, do you think?" She says abruptly, her eyes searching Adora's face. Her jaw is set and her eyes are wide as they demand *something* from Adora.

"Done anything?" She asks, wondering what Catra is thinking. She's not sure what she expected as a reaction to her coming out but whatever it was, it isn't *this*.

Catra picks at the throw blanket next to her on the couch. "Never mind."

Adora feels like the butt of a joke. "No. Say what you're thinking." Why won't she just say something, anything, whatever's on her mind.

She shakes her head in response. "It's not going to help anything."

"Just be honest, Cat." Adora huffs.

"I can keep my thoughts to myself if I want to, Adora." She snarks back, standing up from the couch.

"Stop being so fucking cagey about it and just say whatever it is you want." Adora's nerves give way to frustration.

She breathes out loudly through her nose, pacing the living room. "I'm just trying to wrap my head around you being gay."

"What like it's hard to believe?" She laughs and rolls her eyes. Everyone she'd come out to had said the same thing. *It's about damn time Adora.*

Catra's lips curl into a sneer. "No, because I've spent half my life telling myself you don't want me because you couldn't want *any* woman." She rubs her temples. "Guess the issue was specific to *me*."

Adora's tongue feels too big to fit in her mouth. "Catra, I—" *I've always wanted you. I don't know what it means to stop.* The words are frozen at the tip of her tongue just begging to be sent out into the world.

Catra shakes her head as if dispelling the thoughts. "I'm sorry, I'm happy for you. It's my fault for digging up things that should lay in the past. It doesn't matter anymore."

"Doesn't it?" Adora manages to say as she holds Catra's eyes for the first time since coming out.

She turns and Catra's in front of her again and it feels like she's always hurting her. "What do you want, Adora?" She begs with her eyes for Adora *to just say it*.

Adora bites her lip. She's barely been out for a month, and the ink on the divorce papers has barely dried. She can't just throw herself into Catra's arms even though it's really all she wants right now.

Instead of saying all that, a small, "I guess you're right," slips through her lips.

Catra deflates looking tired. "I'm going to go to sleep now. Long flight and all."

Catra's barely in the next room before Adora starts to cry in earnest. Trying to muffle the sound with her hands so the woman she loves doesnt hear .

And One

She's been staring at her door for at least ten minutes now. It's a wonder she hasnt burned through it with her stare.

She knows it's stupid and out of the blue and heaven knows she doesn't deserve it. She thinks she almost puked on the plane at least seven different times on the four-hour flight here but now her hands are trembling, raised to knock on Catra's door.

Glimmer's words keep spinning in her head.

How long are you going to wait until you get your head out of your ass, Adora? Are you planning on waiting until Catra has her own wife and kids to worry about before you get over yourself and just talk *to her?*

She'd been hemming and hawing about how awkward things have been between her and Catra since her disastrous coming out when Glimmer delivered the killing blow.

Something about the image just snapped her clean in two. She wants Catra to be happy, fulfilled, to have everything her heart desires, but a long-buried part of her wants more than anything to be in that picture with Catra.

She just hopes it's not too late.

She's about to knock~~sh~~ she swears she is~~bu~~t the door opens and she hears a soft yelp.

"Adora?" Catra sounds both sleepy and befuddled. She's wearing black leggings and a flannel shirt Adora recognizes as hers from eons ago. Her hair is rumpled and she's rubbing the sleep out of her eyes as she sends a questioning look Adora's way, probably wondering what the hell she's doing at her doorstep.

Everything she thought about saying, all the notes she prepped and practiced on the plane blink out of her head.

"You're so beautiful." She breathes out. Catra has always been beautiful inside and out. Her heart had been screaming it since Catra was sixteen sitting shyly on Adora's bed declaring her feelings out in the open.

"Um, thank you?" She says, eyeing Adora with worry. She picks up her hands and places the back of it atop her forehead. "It doesn't feel like you have a fever." She mutters absentmindedly.

Adora takes the opportunity to grab her hand gently placing a kiss on her palm. She doesn't let go. She never wants to ever again.

"Can I come inside?" She asks, not shying away from Catra anymore.

Catra is shaken, her eyes raking up and down Adora as if that would answer whatever questions are rolling through her head. "Yeah, Or. You're always welcome." She finally answers.

"So, what brings you all the way out to Bright Moon." She tries to act like it's normal for Adora to catch a cross-country flight and show up at Bright Moon early on Saturday morning.

"You." She swallows down her tears suddenly overwhelmed. "Catra, I love you."

Catra freezes looking at Adora with wide eyes, jaw slightly dropped.

"You don't have to feel the same. But I couldn't wait another moment to tell you."She takes a gasping breath. She's pretty sure this is what dying feels like. "For a long time, I just didn't accept myself. I didn't think there was anything wrong with liking women, but I just didn't allow myself to even think that could be me."

She looks down for a moment biting her lip when she looks up Catra is still listening.

"And then I finally let myself think that I was allowed to want things and be myself. And I started dating women and I thought maybe I could let myself just *be*."She took a step closer , risking putting a hand on Catra's cheek the way she's always wanted to, the way she's dreamed of. "When you brought up what I wanted, I freaked out. It wasn't that I didn't want you. I wanted you too much. I didn't think I could let myself have you. I mean, I'm recently divorced and I just started seeing women and accepting myself and it just felt like too much."She rushes to explain.

"I didn't want to screw things up with you because you're everything to me."She runs a thumb up and down her cheek, the other hand clenching at her side as she looks down in shame. "And then I managed to bungle it all up anyways by freezing up on you and I just ~~"S~~he's crying now ~~I w~~ish I could go back and change so many things. I wish I'd told you I loved you ages ago. But I can't take back what a coward I've been."

She takes a deep breath on the home stretch now. "I've loved you my whole life, Catra. And I'm sorry it's taken me this long to admit it. If you want me, I'm right here."She lets out a short watery laugh. "If you don't that's alright too. Ill always be your best friend."

She'll always wonder if she'd been braver sooner if maybe she could have been happy with Catra. How many years they could've had together. She'll have to settle for knowing she's trying now.

Catra's hand is on top of hers on her cheek and for a moment Adora doesnt want anything to change.

"You shouldn't regret it." Are the first words Catra says to her.

She tilts her head. "Huh?"

"Finn." She says as if it's self-explanatory. Which, it kind of is.

"Of course, I don't regret Finn." She agrees softly.

"What do you want, Adora?" This time instead of anguish, Catra's face holds a quiet wonder that makes Adora feel warm.

"You, Catra. It's always been you. It'll always be you." She promises.

"You're serious about this?" She asks again, a small smile edging on her lips.

Adora gives two snappy nods. "I'm yours, Cat. I'm sorry it took me so long to figure it out."

Suddenly instead of Catra being in front of her, she's in her arms, their lips interlocked. Adora grunts in surprise but then she's wrapping her hand tighter around her waist and pulling her even closer.

Adora has never felt a kiss like this. Catra's lips are so soft and she feels absolutely perfect in her arms, lithe and graceful, beautiful in every way.

"Adora, are you crying?" Catra asks sounding mildly horrified. Adora blinks and realizes she's full-on sobbing.

"Hap-Happy." She gives up on talking and just pulls Catra closer, resting her head on her shoulder and dropping kisses anywhere she can reach. She feels Catra relax against her, although her breathing is still heavy. "So you um" Adora sniffles "want to do this? Be mine?"

Catra looks at her with a goofy smile, eyes shining bright as she pulls Adora close again. "You're such an idiot."

She seals it with a kiss.

End Notes

Comphet is real folks. That's the PSA of the day.

I THINK this is the angstiest thing I've written? Please let me know what you think!

This idea just stole my brain and wouldn't give it back until I wrote it so I didn't have much of a choice. I cried thinking about it.

Please send me comments and kudos it's literally all I want in life. Also follow me on Twitter @esFlower1 :)

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!